
UNIT 8 DEVELOPMENT OF RADIO

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8.0 INTRODUCTION

In the previous units you have been introduced to the growth and development of media. In fact if you introspect you will understand that history of media's growth is the history of the development of technology. Therefore we see that all media rediscover themselves according to the demand and the necessity of time.

In this unit we will trace out the growth and development of Radio in the Indian and International perspective. It will be interesting to unite the refinement of technology in the journey of radio's development.

8.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

The objective of this unit is to apprise you with the historical development of Radio as a technology as well as media. At the end of this unit you should be able to:

- describe the historiography of Radio;
- explain the philosophy that defined Radio in India; and
- analyse the political economy of its growth in India.

8.2 HISTORY OF RADIO

8.2.1 International Perspective

Radio as a means of communication achieved prominence during the World War II. It was used in military activities to communicate from one base to the other and carried orders and commands. The technological development of radio was regarded as a revolutionary discovery of the modern world. In 1887 German Scientist, Heinrich Rudolf Hertz demonstrated that electromagnetic waves can be transmitted through space and his name got attached to denote the unit of radio frequencies. Italian engineer Guglielmo Marconi received the first trans-Atlantic wireless signal from England to Newfoundland in 1901. In the US in 1910 inventor Lee de Forest conducted live radio broadcast from the Metropolitan Opera House in New York and it is regarded as the landmark wireless voice and music transmission. These random developments in various levels added to the growth of Radio as the medium of the masses.

In the West the development of radio as the medium of dissemination of information was taken seriously. In fact with the development of commercial broadcasting, public service broadcasting was also taken up by the state quite sincerely. The history of public service broadcasting is generally traced to British Broadcasting Corporation of England. The thrust of public service broadcasting is still very much relevant in the Third World countries. But in some countries, it has been relegated to being the mouth piece of the state rather than the public.

With the UN project of Information and Communication Technology for Development (ICT4D), radio has gained immense importance in the modern globalised world. However it is important that radio adapt to the new and challenging conditions.

8.2.2 National Perspective

Radio came to India during the British rule in the guise of an amateur experiment. In 1920 the Bombay Presidency Radio Club was established by express support of Giachand Motwane. He is also credited with the honour of being the first one to record and broadcast radio programme in India. It is noteworthy that just a few months before the Radio Club in Bombay, British Broadcasting Corporation (BBC) was given the go ahead to launch a public service programming across Britain by the British government in January 1927. The state involvement started later and when India got independence the baton of Radio was passed from one government to the other. The 1990s saw new development and a lot of hopes were pinned on to the medium. However a critical review now makes the picture hazy. In the next section we will try to give a comprehensive idea about the growth trajectory in detail.

8.3 RADIO IN COLONIAL TIME

8.3.1 Amateur Radio

As mentioned above Radio in India was an amateurish experiment. The venture of Motwane which had the call sign of 2KC lasted for only one day. Next year in a joint venture between the newspaper 'Times of India' and Post and Telegraph office another station was launched in Bombay (now Mumbai), the signals of which were received 100 miles away in Pune. The third station by the call sign of 2FV with the power of 750 kHz and a 1.5 kW transmitter was started in

Bombay after two years. Bombay had a fourth station when Walter Rogers Company started one with the call sign of 2AX. It was more of an Adventist church venture.

On the Eastern region, in Calcutta (now Kolkata), the Marconi Company of England conducted a number of test broadcast in various locations. Eventually Calcutta Radio Club loaned a transmitter from Marconi Company and started their radio station in November 1923 with the call sign of 2BZ. The West Bengal government too loaned a transmitter from Marconi Company and launched a station with the call sign of 5AF.

Similar activities could be seen in Madras (now Chennai) during the same period. The Madras Presidency Radio Club under the call sign of 2GR started operating in 1924 with Viscount Goshan, Governor of Madras as patron. This station closed down in 1927 due to financial constraints and the transmitter was donated to the Corporation of Madras, who operated with the international call sign of VUM.

There were two other stations – one in Madras and one in Bangalore. The station in Madras was operated by the Crompton Electric Company. Both the stations were operating in 1926. There was also a 1 watt station which was established by a postal official at his home in Hyderabad in 1933.

8.3.2 State Involvement

State involvement in broadcasting began when Government of India signed a contract with a private company named Indian Broadcasting Company (IBC) Ltd. in 1927 allowing them to begin experimental broadcasting in Bombay and Calcutta simultaneously. It is mentionable here that this was the same time that following the publication of the Crawford Report (2 March, 1926) British Broadcasting Corporation was launched (1 January, 1927), which was supposed to be non-commercial and crown-chartered. In fact by 1926, it was already being discussed in the Government about formalising the system and structures of broadcasting. It is said that the rules of the Radio Clubs were brought to a forced end as IBC thought that the sale of radio licence could earn them handsome revenue. In fact Fielden had written in his book *Broadcasting in India*, how the most successful of India's Radio Clubs, the Madras Presidency Radio Club, was finally forced to close down in October 1927. However setting up of the first operational transmitters in Bombay and Calcutta took one year and considerable cost was incurred. Even the company was also underfinanced with only 42,000 pound. To make things worse, the company could not sell as many licences as they had thought they would: only 3,594 were issued by the end on 1927. India's geographical reality also came in the way. It was vast and had no electricity.

Thus the company started to feel increasingly that the realities of Britain were not to be found in India. BBC which was operating on the same commercial monopoly agreement between 1922 and 1926 was expanding rapidly in Britain. However IBC by 1930 had opened only two small transmitters and had issued less than 8,000 licences. Moreover programmes were also mostly in English. In fact Secretary of State, Lord Birkenhead had written to Lord Irwin in a personal letter that IBC should make programme for "English Speaking Population, that is to say Europeans and the educated Indians of the cities", totally ignoring the masses. Thus in spite of government support, IBC turned out to be a financial failure. Ultimately in 1930, IBC went into liquidation and was forced to shut shop before

the completion of the fourth year.

However if you look at the broadcasting activities in India before 1930, it will be obvious that a lot of speculative business was taking place in the area, for example, shipping of radio sets, transmitters etc. These people along with the programmers and the public put pressure on the government and government yielded and took over the Bombay and the Madras stations in April 1930. Government of India decided to purchase the assets of IBC and those were placed under the control of the Department of Industry and Labour. 1930 was also the time of 'Civil Disobedience Movement' and the government could see the potential of the newly redesignated Indian State Broadcasting Services (ISBS) being utilised in the consolidation of the Indian state as well as of political unity. The post war great depression also had an effect on the financial condition of the government of India. This financial difficulties and the lack of real enthusiasm on the part of the government to continue with broadcasting led to the closure of IBC on October 1931.

The rumour in Britain was that the radio stations of Bombay and Calcutta might be sold to American commercial interest. The Federation of British Industry was visibly worried and they lobbied in the India Office against the sell-off. Representations and agitations compelled the government to go back on the orders on November 23, 1931; doubling the cess on the radio sets. In 1932 the British Broadcasting Corporation started an Empire Service and it resulted in the doubling of the sale of the receiving sets in less than two years. All these sets were imported at that time. The increase in the collection of license fees and import duty on the sets and components of the radio sets also resulted in the increase of government's revenue. However it should be remembered that though the number of listeners increased, it still remained confined to the elite. This picture of financial viability of broadcasting culminated in the government's decision to start a radio station in Delhi. Delhi station went on air on January 1, 1936.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your Answers.
2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1. What are call signs?

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2. Name five radio clubs in India

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3. Explain what are IBC and ISBS?

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This development was very important as Radio began to be used as an indispensable medium of propaganda and this was directed at two enemies of the Empire: the nascent Congress led independence movement and the alliance specifically Germany. It is well documented in the directive issued by the Empire Intelligence Service (1940) how radio was linked to intelligence gathering: “we need our intelligence organisation on the spot, with headquarters in Bombay, controlled and administered by a specially chosen Indian...It is clear that the co-operation of All India Radio would be essential but there is every reason to suppose that it would be cheerfully forthcoming. The organisation would also be able to produce a skeleton service of information about Burma”.

The first Director General of BBC, John Reith, who is acknowledged as the father of Public Service Broadcasting, was expressing his interest in Indian Broadcasting. He wrote to the Viceroy, Willingdon on the issue of state level broadcasting in India. Willingdon was quite interested in the idea and in 1934 he wrote back to Reith that he should help Willingdon to find someone to work on a five year contract. Reith had written in his autobiography, *Into the Wind*, how he himself had mulled the idea of taking up the assignment only to be negated by the higher authorities. The man selected from BBC was Lionel Fielding, to shape up AIR the lines of BBC. Fielding therefore was not quite happy with the use of broadcasting for intelligence activities. But Reith and Fielding’s vision to build up broadcasting in India in the line of BBC remained a distant dream. It was made clear to Reith that AIR will not be modelled in the self governing style of BBC rather it will remain with the Industries and Labour Department as it already was since 1930.

Fielding was not happy with the name ISBS, he wanted a name which would have an all-India personality. He coerced the Viceroy Linlithgow into adopting the name All India Radio (AIR) in 1936. Fielden recruited the help of devoted young people and with their help and his Chief Engineer, Goyder, he started short-wave transmission in 1938 and gave AIR a wider coverage. Lucknow station was started on April 2, 1938 and Madras station on June 16, same year. In 1939 the Trichur station went on air and in the same year the external services also started. Fielden went on medical leave in 1939 and returned briefly only to permanently leave Indian soil by 1940.

This was also a time when other hand people like Frank Lugard Brayne, (a civil servant in the Gurgaon district) and few others advocated the usage of radio for the uplift of the rural community. This resulted in the establishment of rural radio stations (somewhat similar to the concept of community radio now) in places like the rural outskirts of the Northern cities of Lahore, Delhi and Peshawar, in Southern Madras, Midnapore district of Bengal and princely state of Hyderabad. These stations were eventually incorporated into the All India Radio network after 1937.

Another very interesting development was taking place during this period. Indian Nationalist movement was at its peak and the nationalist groups started exploring the issue of ‘illegal’ counter broadcasting. From 1940 onwards there have been

evidences of amateur radio operators setting up pro-Congress stations like the Azad Hind Radio etc. This radio station started operating on 26th August 1st 1942 after the arrest of Mahatma Gandhi when All India Congress Committee decided to demand British to Quit India. The station was broadcasting on 41.78 meters. As it was a secret radio it had to be shifted many times to escape detection.

Historian Gautam Chatterjee says, “According to the old records, Vitthal Rao Patvardhan brought a broadcasting equipment of the Congress Radio (which Madhav Limaye called Azad Radio) to Nasik. It was kept in Sankaracharya Math from where the *Azad Radio* went on air. But perhaps fearing police raid, the transmission equipment was immersed in the Godavari River.”

“At those dark hours of new black-out, the Congress Radio went on air and worked as an inspiration for the masses. It spread the message of secularism, internationalism, brotherhood and freedom,” he says.

“Ram Manohar Lohia and Vithaldas Madhavji Khakar were given the responsibility to organize broadcasting messages and programmes during the movement, he says. Khakar was the chief organiser of the Congress Radio Enterprises and was answerable to Lohia,” he says.

Two amateur radio broadcasters ‘Bob’ Tanna and Nariman Abarbad Printer played a key role in setting up Congress radio. Owen Williamson says:

Despite sporadic British jamming, the crystal-controlled signal of Congress radio was audible on then-unoccupied 40-metre band throughout the Indian subcontinent, and as far away as Japanese-occupied Burma. The station transmitted recordings of the Mahatma’s sermons and calls for non violence, uncensored news, pro-independence, instructions for Gandhian activists, and political declaration by the movements’ underground leadership....(‘The Mahatma’s Hams’, <http://www.wr6wr.com/newsSite/articles/features/mahatmashams.html>)

The first Indian administrator of AIR was A. S. Bokhari, who was groomed by Fielden. He was the Director General during all the war years and all during the independence movement and the partition too. A new broadcasting house was built on the Parliament Street, New Delhi. On June 3, 1947, Lord Mountbatten (the then Viceroy), Jawaharlal Nehru and Mohd. Ali Jinnah gave their historical speeches through AIR.

Check Your Progress 2

- Note:** 1) Use the space provided below for your Answers.
2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1. Write short notes on:

a) John Reith

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b) Lionel Fielding

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2. Write about the phenomenon of pirate radio during the independence movement.

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8.4 RADIO AFTER INDEPENDENCE

When the British left India, it was a divided India. Thus India was left with only six Stations at Delhi, Mumbai, Kolkata, Chennai, Lucknow and Tiruchirapalli with 18 transmitters (six on the Medium Wave or MW and the rest on Short Wave or SW). The coverage area was 2.5% and 11% of the population. Radio listening on MW was confined to urban areas.

The importance of the role of communication for national development was underscored in India even prior to her independence. The Indian National Congress while formulating policies for National Development for Independent India set up a Sub-committee on Communication under the National Planning Committee to offer recommendations for development of communication for independent India. The report of the National Planning committee cited the following as the target of broadcasting for independent India: “(a) Dissemination of news and useful information; (b) Adult education; fighting rural ignorance; (c) Propaganda by the State and (d) Entertainment” (NPC: section 13). After independence of the country in 1947, the new Indian government announced a development-oriented agenda of governance dedicated to the amelioration of the economic, educational, and health conditions of the people.

With the target of Development Communication, the new government adopted the recommendations of the erstwhile National Planning Committee as the mainstay of its communication policies. P C Joshi in his book *Communication and National Development* had written: “The issue of using modern communication acquired high priority as a developmental resource during the Nehru era when the planners explored the prospects of using radio as a development agent, that is, for information and enlightening the people in the countryside and towns on developmental issue”.

It is to be noted here that the post independence growth plan was charted by the Tatas and Birlas by drafting the Bombay Plan also called *A Plan for Economic Development of India*. It was drafted by J.R.D. Tata and G.D. Birla and was extensively discussed in the Birla-owned journal called the *Eastern Economist*. This plan had supported private enterprise and protectionist politics in support of indigenous capital. However the state remained the nodal agency in the area of economic growth. In 1955 was adopted the Industrial Policy Statement in the

Avadi session of the Congress government. In this policy, basic and strategic industries, including heavy industrial plants etc. were all reserved for development in public sector. Similarly in the Industrial Policy resolution of 1956, telecommunication, broadcasting and defence equipment was also reserved for the public sector.

8.4.1 Post colonial period

In the First Five Year plan, no financial allotment was done for the broadcasting sector neither any mention was made on it. But investment to the tune of 4.94 crores was done and by 1956, most of the region was covered by AIR. Second Five Year plan envisaged wider coverage and for the first time plan document spoke about setting up a television station with an allocation of 40 lakh. Of the entire plan allocation of 9 crores the maximum amount i.e. 267.81 lakh was earmarked for studio installation and additional office accommodation. Hence the focus was on infrastructure development. And this trend continued.

However the growth had not been as fast. By 1960 56% of the population and 37% of the country's area was covered by medium wave services. Therefore the majority of the area was left to short wave coverage which was not clear. In fact Mehra Masani in her book *Broadcasting and the People* writes that even in 1984 a reliable medium-wave service could reach only 90% of the population and 75% of the geographical area. Which according to her means that radio was accessible to 20% of the population which was mainly in the urban area.

We need to remember that during that time the system of collecting licence fee was in force. A person with a radio set was required to deposit a fee amount at the local post office to ensure continuing reception of signals. This is what we do now to keep receiving the television signals in our sets through the Digital TV set box. And it is still in vogue in UK as far as BBC is concerned. BBC has been able to retain its autonomy largely because of the licence fees that they collect, thus they do not depend on the government fund for sustenance. This system of collecting licence fee was eventually abolished in the 1970s.

After 1968 the annual rate of increase in licences has fallen steadily and the numbers of household with radio sets were only about 25 million. Even the production of sets witnessed a slow decline. Radio sets were more in demand than could be supplied during the period of 1960-70. But the demand declined after that. But this was the time when Green Revolution in India was in full swing and AIR had been a close companion of the revolution. It was naturally expected that the demand will increase for the sets. But it did not happen as expected. In spite of the slowdown in the listeners' base the setting up of stations and transmitters went on. As Masani had noted most of the transmitters were set up as a part of political necessities.

It is mentionable here that, in 1962 India fought a war with China in the North-Eastern front. This war revealed the inadequacy of the reception of radio signals in the border areas. As a follow up the government constituted a committee on broadcasting and Information media, popularly known as the Chanda Committee, on the 14th of December, 1964. The committee reviewed the operation of various media units under the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting. It submitted a report on Radio and Television on 18 April 1966.

The committee felt that it was not possible in the Indian context for a creative medium like broadcasting to flourish under the regimentation of departmental rules and regulations. Therefore it recommended the constitution of a separate corporation for radio and television. The report also suggested that both of them be given freedom to evolve their own recruitment rules, pay and service condition according to their varied and peculiar necessities. Another recommendation was for the starting of a commercial service. And it was started from Vividh Bharati in 1967.

However, In April 1970, the Lok Sabha was informed by the government that it was not the opportune time to consider the conversion of AIR into an autonomous corporation. But, a major structural change was accepted i.e. to separate Radio and Television and Doordarshan came into existence on April 1, 1976 under the I&B Ministry.

Soon after the internal emergency, a white paper on the misuse of the mass media during the emergency was presented to the parliament in August 1977. In the elections, the opposition parties presented freedom of expression including autonomy to electronic media as a major election plank.

After the new Janata Party government took charge, the working group on Autonomy for AIR and DD was constituted by the Ministry of I&B by a gazette notification dated August 17, 1977, under the Chairmanship of B. G. Verghese with 11 members.

Important amongst the major recommendations was that of setting up of an independent public corporation acting impartially, as Trustee in the public interest referred to as Akash Bharati in the tune of National Broadcasting Trust. The Working committee did not want two separate corporations for Akashvani and Doordarshan, but suggested a highly decentralized four-tier broadcasting organisation at central, zonal, regional and local levels.

India hosted the Asian Games in 1982 and television which was till then at a nascent stage received a major boost. In 1984, Rajiv Gandhi became the Prime Minister of India and he was very keen on the medium. The entire political focus shifted to the new medium. The popularity of AIR also declined. There was a general apathy in the government to rejuvenate the medium.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your Answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1. India has a very strong population which is underdeveloped; we cannot have radio for profit.

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8.4.2 Time of Free Airwaves

1990s was a very critical period for India both politically and economically. India was suffering from internal political instability and the fragile National Front coalition faced a nationwide crisis in the summer of 1990 over its affirmative action policies. By autumn, a campaign by the BJP to build a Hindu temple at the site of a 16th century mosque in Ayodhya resulted in widespread communal violence. The government collapsed when the BJP pulled out. A new minority government failed to pass the scheduled budget in February 1991 when it lost the Congress Party's external support. In May 1991, while campaigning for the general elections, Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi was assassinated. In reaction, and in parallel to these developments, the economic situation worsened. By September 1990, net inflows of Non-Resident Indian deposits had turned negative. Access to commercial borrowing had become more costly, and by December even short-term credit was restricted. Foreign exchange reserves fell to \$1.2 billion in January 1991. By the time a new government took over in June, reserves could cover only two weeks of imports. India was close to defaulting on its sovereign debt for the first time in its history. And thus India negotiated a \$1.8 billion loan from IMF (International Monetary Fund) with conditions. The condition applied by IMF resulted in the Structural Adjustment Programme (SAP) which pre-empted the involvement of the state in state expenditures in many welfare sectors including health and education. Neoliberalism had entered India with full force.

PRASAR BHARATI:

Prasar Bharati Broadcasting Corporation of India (BCI) Act was enacted with the objective to confer autonomy on Akashvani and Doordarshan, thereby ensuring that they function in a fair, objective and creative manner. The Prasar Bharati Act provided a direction and pointer, which should govern the broadcasting policies.

In fact, the demand for autonomy for AIR and TV dates back to mid-sixties, when the first ever expert committee (the Chanda Committee) went into the issue.

The Prasar Bharati Bill of 1989 is largely based on the Verghese Report (1978) and the Prasar Bharati Bill (1979) that was introduced by the Janata regime in Parliament in May, 1979. While the Prasar Bharati Bill favors the creation of a broadcasting corporation through an act of Parliament. The Verghese Report clearly wanted broadcasting autonomy to be a part of the Indian Constitution. This would be necessary to ensure that no future government would tamper with the freedom and independence of the corporation. The bill manages to sneak in a representative of MIB as a part time governor. This is not the 'full autonomy' the Verghese Committee had in mind. The bill of 1979 became an Act in 1990 with approval by all political parties in the Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha.

The first step the ruling Congress Government took in response to the 'invasion' by cross-border satellite television was to set up the Varadam Committee (1991)

to re-examine the Prasar Bharati Act of 1990. The Ram Vilas Paswan Committee was set up for this purpose in 1995. It submitted a 104 page working paper with 46 recommendations on public and private electronic media, newspapers, news agencies and films. The committee had hammered out consensus on National Media Policy. Some of the recommendations were incorporated in the Broadcasting Bill introduced in Parliament in May, 1997. The Nitish Sengupta Committee (1996) was constituted in 1996 to have another look at the Prasar Bharati Act and to suggest amendments. It submitted its report in August of the same year.

The Prasar Bharati Bill remains a dead letter with the successive governments never being serious about autonomy for the official electronic media. The government is more interested in revenue but without proper service condition or focused programme presentation earning revenue can only remain a dream and Prasar Bharati a mirage.

This was also the time when the Supreme Court of India gave a ruling declaring airwaves as public property which came in 1995. This translated into the radio sector being opened up to private players. Now a handful of big business houses, with non media and media interests have dominated the FM radio market. The then Finance Minister P. Chidambaram had announced the licensing of 295 more radio stations in 2013-14. It is interesting to note that private FM channels are mainly urban centric and plays 24X7 film songs. News is not allowed to be broadcast yet.

Another offshoot of this order of the Supreme Court was the opening up of the airwaves for Community Radio. Several non-governmental organisations and media-activist groups campaigned for nearly a decade for the right to set up local radio broadcasting facilities to support their community development work. They also networked to further the cause of community radio in the country. This network, soon after the announcement of the community radio policy, came together in January 2007 to constitute the Community Radio Forum (CRF) of India. CRF has espoused the mandate to support and promote the setting up of community radio stations in India and to lobby for policy changes that would amplify the progressive nature of the community radio policy and further simplify and democratize the licensing procedures.

The Bangalore-based communication campaign group, 'VOICES' convened a gathering of radio broadcasters, policy planners, media professionals and not-for-profit associations in September 1996 to study how community radio could be relevant to India, and to deliberate on policies appropriate for such an action. A Declaration calling for the establishment of community broadcasting was signed. A suggestion that AIR's local stations should allocate regular airtime for community broadcasting was put forward. Requests were also made for grant of licences to NGOs and other non-profit making groups for running community radio stations. Subsequently, UNESCO made available a portable production and transmission "briefcase radio station" kit to VOICES to do experimental broadcasts of programmes for a hands-on learning experience towards the objective of setting up an independently-run community radio station.

A UNESCO sponsored workshop, hosted by an Andhra Pradesh NGO, Deccan Development Society (DDS) from July 17-20, 2000 in Hyderabad issued the 'Pastapur Initiative' on community radio that urged the government to take its intentions of freeing broadcasting from state monopoly to its logical conclusion, by making media space available not only to private players but also to communities. This landmark document urged the government to create a three-tier structure of broadcasting in India by adding non-profit community radio to the already existing state-owned public radio and private commercial radio.

The spirited campaigning for communities' right to access the airwaves and innumerable representations by organisations, academicians and individuals resulted in the MIB organising a workshop supported by the UNDP and UNESCO in May 2004 in New Delhi to design an enabling framework for community radio in India. The workshop brought together a large number of community radio enthusiasts, academics, NGOs and policy makers, who worked out a set of recommendations for a new community radio policy, one that would allow community groups to run their own radio stations. When the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI) issued a consultation paper later that year, they arrived at largely the same formulations for community radio.

In July 2004 MIB prepared a draft policy based on the May consultations. Subsequently, community radio groups in India launched an online petition campaign, urging the inclusion of the right of communities within the community radio policy and thereby ending the discrimination against rural and poor communities. In October 2005, the draft policy was referred to a group of ministers, who took about a year to give its approval after deliberating upon several contentious issues such as advertising, news and information, licence fee, and spectrum availability.

These intense advocacy efforts and passionate debates about community radio broadcasting for the social sector finally capitulated into an inclusive community radio policy approved by the Union Cabinet in November 2006.

As of 2012 there are 125 functioning Community Radio Stations in India. Of these 125 stations more than 90 are Campus Radio station located either in the campus of educational institute or Krishi Vigyan Kendras.

By the end of March 2018, there were 238 functioning community radio stations in India. Out of these, 135 were campus radio stations located in educational institutes, Krishi Vigyan Kendras and State Agricultural Universities.

The post 90s time has seen a very interesting trajectory. The most important feature of this time as far as media is concerned is the growing presence of the private sector in media, where state's role has been diminished to being an 'enabler'. Even the state media apparatuses, Doordarshan and AIR have been following the revenue model of the private media houses.

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your Answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1. News is not allowed to be broadcast in Private FM Channels as well as in Community Radio. Do you think it is justified? Explain.

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8.5 LOOKING AT THE FUTURE

The future of radio in India seems to be a bit hazy. While state owned AIR seem to have lost the way in the dense forest of governmental apathy, the only flourishing arm of radio seems to be the private FM channels. Community Radio is yet to find a grip in the country with governmental control making it quite tough to survive.

With rapid digitisation and internet access the next gen is getting more and more hooked to satellite radio. But the role of AIR and Community Radio cannot be brushed off in a country like India. A serious political will is necessary to catapult the medium from the fake inertia that it is suffering from at present.

8.6 LET US SUM UP

We hope that by now you have understood the way radio had grown in India. From an amateurish attempt to the governmental project it had seen numerous ups and downs. Post independence when our first Prime Minister visualised radio as a medium of propaganda, he also simultaneously opined that radio is the medium which was important for dissemination of information to the poor masses. But with the growing politicisation of radio, it has been left as a state propaganda mechanism of the ruling party. On the other hand the space for private radio has been opened up unbridled albeit without the independence of broadcasting news. Thus radio has survived and will survive as India remains a class divided country.

8.7 FURTHER READINGS

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2. Broadcasting and the People: Mehra Masani (1976). National Book Trust of India.
3. Pinkerton, Alasdair, (2008), Radio and the Raj: Broadcasting in British India (1920-1940), JRAJ, series 3, 28, 2 (2008), pp. 167-191 c-doi: 10.1017/S1356186307008048 The Royal Asiatic Society.

8.8 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

See 8.3.1, 8.3.2

Check Your Progress 2

See 8.3.2

Check Your Progress 3

See 8.4.1

Check Your Progress 4

See 8.4.2